regions of India. It was as close as one could get to the creation of what Ambedkar repeatedly described as the goal of ‘fraternity’. The Yatra provided a brief glimmer of it.

The last time a yatra caught the nation’s attention was L.K. Advani’s ‘Rath Yatra’ atop a modified Toyota bus in the 1980s, which traversed the country, inciting anti-Muslim sentiments, leaving a trail of riots and bloodshed in its wake and resulting in mobs tearing down a sixteenth-century mosque. The current Indian government’s ideology is built on that Yatra’s legacy (and the incumbent Prime Minister was one of the key organizers of that hate-inducing yatra).[5] In stark contrast, the yatris I walked with held up the image of an alternative India that challenged the legitimacy of a regime bloated with hubris, and drunk on power and violence. The question that I came away with was: Which path will the Indian population choose to take?

---

1 ‘How the Indian Government Uses Raids to Silence Critics’, *Time*, 16 February 2023, https://time.com/6255425/india-raid-bbc-modi-documentary/

2 Rupa Subramanya, ‘Modi Risks Turning India into a Nation of Gangster Capitalists’, Nikkei Asia, 5 February 2021, https://asia.nikkei.com/Opinion/Modi-risks-turning-India-into-a-nation-of-gangster-capitalists

3 Anando Bhakto, ‘India’s Press Freedom Ranking Dips Sharply, According to Analysis by Media Watchdog Reporters Without Borders’, *The Frontline*, 3 May 2023, https://frontline.thehindu.com/news/narendra-modi-india-press-freedom-ranking-falls-in-media-watchdog-reporters-without-borders-index/article66807884.ece

4 Sahil Bhalla, ‘By Pulling Zuckerberg Aside, Modi Demonstrated That He Always Knows Where the Camera Is’, *Dawn*, 29 September 2015, https://www.dawn.com/news/1209729